

The biblical commandment "You shall not steal" from Exodus 20:15 is supported by specific legal guidelines in Exodus 22:1–4. These laws required anyone who stole to repay the victim significantly more than the original value of the property. For example, a thief might have to pay back double the value of a stolen item or even four to five times the value for livestock, ensuring the victim was fully compensated while discouraging future theft.

A Modern Perspective on Ancient Restorative Justice

- **Fair Compensation:** If stolen goods were recovered, the thief was required to return twice the value, ensuring the victim was compensated for their loss and trouble.
- **Higher Penalties for Lost Assets:** For essential property like livestock that couldn't be recovered, penalties were much steeper—up to five times the value—to reflect the greater impact on the victim's livelihood.
- **Accountability for All:** Even those without funds were held accountable through service, ensuring that the debt to the victim was always paid.
- **Self-Defense Limits:** While protecting one's home at night was permitted, the law set clear boundaries to prevent unnecessary violence during the day.
- **Core Values:** These principles aimed to protect personal rights, discourage crime by making it unprofitable, and prioritize restoring the victim's well-being.

Biblical Context The 8th Commandment (Exodus 20:15) forbids all forms of taking what is not yours, while the subsequent "Case Laws" in Exodus 21-22 explain how to handle violations. This system emphasizes that human life is more valuable than property and focuses on restorative justice rather than just retribution.